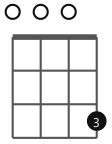
Danny Boy

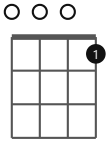
Frederic Weatherly, 1913

Key: **C major** Time: **4/4** Tempo: **66 bpm** Strum: **D-D-D-DU** Starts on: **G7 (V7)**

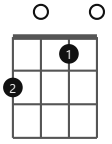
THE CHORDS IN C, AND HOW THEY FEEL



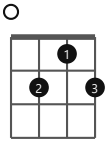
C
I
home



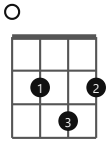
C7
I7
home, leaning on to four



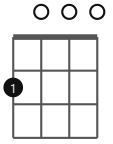
F
IV
away



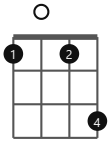
G7
V7
tension (wants to go home)



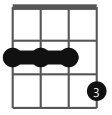
G
V
tension (wants to go home)



Am
vi
the sad home



Fm
iv
the sad four, borrowed from the minor key



D7
II7
the five of five: leads to V

THE SONG

A
Verse 1
Oh Danny boy...

→

A
Verse 2
But when ye...

- 2 parts in the song, but only 1 different chord pattern to learn.
- One chord pattern for the whole song: learn it once, then it's the words.

CHORD MAP

A Verse ×2, new words each time

Oh Danny boy, the pipes, the…	**G7** V7	**C** ① I	**C7** I7	**F** IV	
From glen to glen, and down…	**Fm** iv	**C** I	**Am** vi	**D7** ② II7	**G7** V7
The summer's gone, and all the…	**G7** V7	**C** ③ I	**C7** I7	**F** IV	
It's you, it's you must go…	**C** I	**Am** vi	**G7** V7	**F** IV	**C** I
But come ye back when summer's…	**G** V	**F** IV	**C** ④ I	**F** IV	
Or when the valley's hushed and…	**G** V	**C** I	**Am** vi	**D7** II7	**G** V
It's I'll be here in sunshine…	**C** I	**C7** I7	**F** IV	**Fm** iv	
Oh Danny boy, oh Danny boy…	**C** ⑤ I	**Am** vi	**F** IV	**G7** V7	**C** I

① **Minor four**: C F Fm C, I IV iv I, in the line "Oh Danny boy, the pipes, the…". Four, then four turned minor just before home: a bittersweet sigh, loved in ballads and Beatles songs.

② **Five of five (II7–V7–I)**: D7 G7 C, II V I, in the line "From glen to glen, and down…". A major two leads to five, five leads home: each chord a fifth above the next. Old-time and music-hall songs love it.

③ **Amen (plagal)**: C F C, I IV I, in the line "The summer's gone, and all the…". One, four, one: the "A-men" sound.

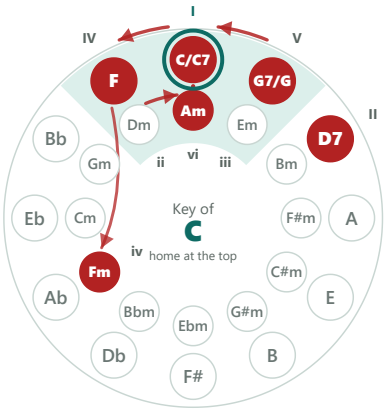
④ **Three-chord trick**: C F G C, I IV V I, in the line "But come ye back when summer's…". One, four, five, home. Folk, country and rock and roll.

⑤ **50s / doo-wop**: C Am F G7, I vi IV V, in the line "Oh Danny boy, oh Danny boy…". Home, sad six, four, five. "Stand by Me", "Earth Angel".

CHANGES TO PRACTISE

1. **F → Fm** (×4): Move your index finger to the G string, 1st fret; move your middle finger to the E string, 1st fret; put your little finger on the A string, 3rd fret.
2. **F → G** (×2): Move your index finger to the C string, 2nd fret; move your middle finger to the A string, 2nd fret; put your ring finger on the E string, 3rd fret.
3. **D7 → G** (×2): Move your index finger to the C string, 2nd fret; move your ring finger to the E string, 3rd fret; put your middle finger on the A string, 2nd fret.
4. **G → F** (×2): Move your index finger to the E string, 1st fret; move your middle finger to the G string, 2nd fret; lift your ring finger.
5. **Am → D7** (×4): Move your index finger across the G C E strings at the 2nd fret (a barre); put your ring finger on the A string, 3rd fret.

ON THE CIRCLE OF FIFTHS



- Home is C, ringed at the top. Its closest chords sit either side: IV to the left, V to the right, and the minors ii, vi and iii inside.
- G7, C, C7, F, Am, G are in the key's family. From outside it:
- Fm: the sad four (iv), borrowed from C minor.
- D7: the five of G (II7): it leads to G.
- C → Am (I → vi), 8 times: to its relative minor, just inside it on the circle.
- G7 → C (V7 → I), 6 times: five to one: the strongest pull home.
- C7 → F (I7 → IV), 6 times: one step anticlockwise (down a fifth): the way music likes to move.
- F → C (IV → I), 6 times: four to one, the "Amen" sound.

LEARNING IT

1. Practise the hardest changes above until they're smooth (Learn → Changes…).
2. Play along with the chords, then **from memory**: the chords hidden after the first time each part comes, then as numbers only, then none (Learn → From memory).
3. Play it in another key, thinking in numbers. If you can, you know the song, not just the shapes.
4. Come back to it in a day or two, and again in a week.

TROUBLE SPOTS

Made with ukemusic on 10 Nov 2026.